

State Agency Promising Practice

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TOPIC:
Capacity Building

Minnesota Transformation Initiative: The State's Department of Human Services Supports the Move from Subminimum Wage to Competitive Integrated Employment

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BACKGROUND

The Minnesota Department of Human Services (DHS) funds and supports the Minnesota Transformation Initiative Technical Assistance Center (MTI). MTI originally focused on reducing the use of subminimum wages but now has an expanded focus on capacity building to support competitive integrated employment outcomes for people with disabilities. The MTI is advancing transformation efforts in Minnesota that began a decade ago.

In 2014, Minnesota's Olmstead Subcabinet adopted its Employment First policy. The policy's stated aim is for people with disabilities to have access to integrated employment opportunities before being offered other services.

In 2018, The University of Minnesota's Institute on Community Integration partnered with the University of Massachusetts's Institute for Community Inclusion to create the Minnesota Technical Assistance Program (MN-TAP). The MN-TAP supported two cohorts of six providers to expand opportunities for competitive integrated employment and decrease reliance on center-based services. MN-TAP supported these providers through technical assistance, training, and instruction modules to build capacity to provide community-based services.

By 2020, some Minnesota providers had made progress on multi-year transformation plans they had designed to comply with the Employment First policy goal. In March

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of 2020, the social distancing restrictions imposed by the COVID-19 public health emergency enforced the physical shutdown of most workplaces, including community rehabilitation providers. With their program sites closed, providers throughout the state focused on delivering services remotely and began considering what providing services might look like once they reopened. In two cases, providers concluded that their best option would be to provide all their services in the community and focused on building their capacity to provide community-based services.

In 2022, DHS received funding from the legislature to reduce the use of subminimum wages. With this funding, DHS awarded a grant to the Institute on Community Integration at the University of Minnesota to establish the MTI and created two provider reinvention grants: 1) Employment Provider Transition (EPT) grants to build capacity to provide competitive integrated employment services, and 2) Transition to Competitive Wages (TCW) grants to adopt a business model designed to support competitive integrated employment and community life engagement outcomes. MTI built a partnership between the Institute on Community Integration, the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston, the Arc of Minnesota, Quillo, and Strengths at Work LLC to offer better support to more providers.



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IMPLEMENTATION

Since 2022, the MTI has provided technical assistance to providers, including 14 EPT grantees and eight TCW grantees. The TCW grantees and most of the EPT grantees participate in a learning community. MTI also offers quarterly virtual transformation and capacity-building trainings open to all providers in Minnesota and a Leadership and Management course for middle managers from organizations receiving TA. MTI recognizes the research-based impact of learning from families and peers by providing training and education directly to families and peer mentoring to self-advocates.

In 2024, Minnesota passed legislation to extend MTI for two additional years. The project will include technical assistance to provider organizations and lead agencies (e.g., counties and Tribal Nations), statewide training offerings, resource development and dissemination, planning and guidance on policy, and piloting of the LifeCourse Connect planning platform.

SUGGESTIONS FOR REPLICATION

- » **Set clear goals.** MTI is based on Minnesota's Employment First Policy that requires and supports competitive integrated employment as the first and preferred option in planning and service delivery for people with disabilities.
- » **Develop and implement training programs to build provider capacity.** MN-TAP and MTI were instrumental in supporting providers to build their staff's capacity to develop and implement organizational transformation plans to transition from subminimum wage employment to competitive integrated employment. Focus training and technical assistance efforts on every level of the organization from senior managers to direct care staff.
- » **Incentivize providers to make changes in line with the project goals.** The availability of funding has been instrumental as an incentive for providers to adopt new business models and service delivery methods. The funding supported significant and sustained investment in education, training, and technical assistance.

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